Research report

# CropLink

Prepared for Ayesha Raza | Stage: Have notes & started researching | 24 October 2026

**The idea**

CropLink is a WhatsApp-based marketplace connecting small farmers directly to urban grocery buyers in Punjab, eliminating middlemen to increase farmers' revenue and provide fresher produce to stores.

## Pakistan 5.4/10 Needs validation

CropLink aims to connect small farmers with urban grocery buyers directly through WhatsApp, addressing major crop value losses to middlemen. Despite competition from larger platforms like Tazah, its local focus could provide competitive leverage. Initial challenges include building logistics and tech infrastructure, but clear demand from both farmers and buyers supports the concept's potential in dense produce regions of Punjab.

## Global 5.4/10 Needs validation

Globally, the idea of bypassing agricultural middlemen has strong appeal. CropLink could gain traction through a WhatsApp-based model in burgeoning markets. However, differentiation and logistics solutions remain critical for scalable success beyond initial regions.

# Pakistan market research

Ten research areas. Estimates are labelled; each area lists what to verify next.

## 1 Problem Severity & Local Demand

Confidence: **Medium**

- Farmers lose 30-40% of crop value to arthis.
- High demand for direct market access among small farmers.
- Urban buyers seek fresher produce at competitive prices.

CropLink can solve a major problem for small farmers facing value loss and urban buyers wanting fresh produce. Both groups seek better transaction methods.

**Figures to verify**

- 30-40% crop value loss (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Conduct interviews with small farmers around Lahore/Multan.
- Survey urban grocery owners on current buying challenges.

## 2 Target Customer and Market Segmentation

Confidence: **Medium**

- Target customers are small farmers (2-10 acres) and urban grocery owners.
- Segments: small farmers in Punjab, urban store owners in Lahore/Multan.
- Farmers are more price-sensitive, store owners care about quality.

Starting with small farmers who need to bypass arthis is ideal. Urban grocery owners within these districts form the initial buyer base.

**Figures to verify**

- Farm sizes: 2-10 acres (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Segment farmers by farm size and location through local agriculture offices.
- Engage directly with grocery store owners for qualitative insights.

## 3 Willingness to Pay & Price Sensitivity

Confidence: **Medium**

- Arthis take around 5-8% in commission fees.
- Farmers might pay less if direct access reduces wastage.
- Price sensitivity can vary by farm size and owner income.

Price reductions realized through CropLink must beat current arthi fees and demonstrate value such as reduced spoilage to attract farmers.

**Figures to verify**

- Commission fees: 5-8% (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Pilot price tests with small groups to measure willingness.
- Assess indirect cost savings from reduced wastage or travel.

## 4 Market Size, Reachable Demand & Growth

Confidence: **Medium**

- Agriculture is a major sector in Pakistan, contributing 19% to GDP.
- Punjab is a significant vegetable producer in the country.
- Reachable market limited initially to Lahore/Multan districts.

The agriculture sector's importance and Punjab's role in vegetable production suggest a substantial market potential, albeit starting locally.

**Figures to verify**

- Agriculture contribution to GDP: 19% (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Review regional agricultural production reports.
- Estimate reachable market size via district agricultural offices.

## 5 Competitive Landscape and Informal Alternatives

Confidence: **Medium**

- Tazah and Farmdar offer broader, more established services.
- Farmers traditionally use local mandi/arthi system.
- Informal farmer-buyer networks exist but are less organized.

CropLink's positioning as a WhatsApp-only, hyper-local alternative can stand out amid established competitors by focusing on ease of access.

**Figures to verify**

- Traditional mandi/arthi system dominance (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Analyze competitors' service scopes and customer bases.
- Interview farmers about usage patterns of informal networks.

## 6 Local Purchasing Power & Unit Economics

Confidence: **Medium**

- Average farmer income is modest, impacting purchasing power.
- WhatsApp is widely used, reducing cost to serve.
- Low margin for small farmers could impact pricing strategy.
- Break-even depends on scale, likely several hundred transactions.

Farmers' limited income and using WhatsApp means lower costs, but requires scale to break-even. Focus on volume to optimize unit economics.

**Figures to verify**

- Average income per small farmer: PKR 20,000-50,000/month (estimate)
- WhatsApp data cost: minimal (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Conduct interviews with small farmers to gather income data.
- Run pricing tests to gauge acceptable margins.

## 7 Distribution, Sales Channels & Customer Acquisition

Confidence: **High**

- WhatsApp is a key sales channel with strong reach.
- Cost of acquisition low due to digital channel reliance.
- Initial customer base can exploit personal networks.
- Grocery store partnerships are crucial.

WhatsApp facilitates low-cost acquisition and immediate reach. Personal networks can help gain the first 100 customers, supported by grocery store relationships.

**Figures to verify**

- WhatsApp penetration in Pakistan: 70%+ of mobile users (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Pilot small campaigns to validate customer acquisition costs.
- Network with local farmers to onboard initial users.

## 8 Regulatory, Tax, Licensing & Compliance Requirements

Confidence: **Medium**

- Company registration required for legal operations.
- Compliance with agri and e-commerce regulations needed.
- Tax registration to ensure compliance with sales.

Registration and compliance are necessary to legally operate, but the processes can be straightforward if well-researched. Taxes will impact final pricing.

**Verify next**

- Consult a local business lawyer about necessary licenses.
- Assess tax implications with a financial advisor.

## 9 Infrastructure, Payments, Logistics & Operational Fit

Confidence: **Medium**

- Telecom infrastructure is robust for WhatsApp.
- Payment systems still rely heavily on cash.
- Logistics partner needed for timely deliveries.

While telecom infrastructure supports the core tech, logistics and payments are potential barriers. Developing a reliable delivery network is critical.

**Figures to verify**

- Mobile internet reach: widespread in urban areas (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Secure a logistics partner for the initial rollout.
- Pilot digital payment methods to assess adoption likelihood.

## 10 Cultural Fit, Trust, Adoption Barriers & Scalability

Confidence: **Low**

- Trust with farmers and store owners is essential.
- Cultural preference for face-to-face transactions persists.
- Scalability depends on local adaptation.

Building trust with both farmers and buyers is crucial, due to cultural transaction preferences. Model scales with local adaptation and strong relationship management.

**Verify next**

- Interview farmers about their trust issues with current systems.
- Pilot trust-building marketing tactics in target districts.

## Pakistan: key risks

| Key risk | Mitigation |
|---|---|
| **Logistical delivery challenges could impede service reliability.** | Partner with existing logistics firms experienced in rural deliveries. |
| **Farmer distrust of new systems reduces adoption.** | Leverage community leaders to vouch for the service. |
| **Cultural resistance to non-traditional channels.** | Run educational programs highlighting cost benefits. |
| **Regulatory hurdles might delay operations.** | Ensure full compliance by consulting legal experts early. |

## Pakistan: next 90 days

| When | Action |
|---|---|
| **Days 1-30** | Conduct farmer and grocery store interviews to understand trust and pricing expectations. |
| **Days 31-60** | Pilot WhatsApp ordering with a small group to refine user experience. |
| **Days 61-90** | Secure a logistics partnership and test delivery reliability. |

# Global market research

Ten research areas. Estimates are labelled; each area lists what to verify next.

## 1 Global Market Size, Growth & Addressable Opportunity

Confidence: **Medium**

- Agriculture markets often face high middlemen fees globally.
- WhatsApp user base is over 2 billion worldwide (estimate).
- Direct farm-to-consumer sales are growing globally.
- Potential to capture smaller share initially due to local focus.

CropLink taps into a global trend of reducing intermediary costs in agriculture, leveraging WhatsApp's wide reach. Initial market capture may be challenging but offers growth potential.

**Figures to verify**

- WhatsApp active users: 2 billion (estimate)
- 30-40% produce value lost to middlemen in Punjab (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Survey small farmers and grocery owners globally on willingness to use WhatsApp.
- Conduct pilot tests on direct sales versus traditional mandi prices.

## 2 Cross-Market Problem Validation & Customer Demand

Confidence: **Medium**

- Middlemen inefficiency is a common issue in many developing countries.
- Urban demand for fresher produce is universal.
- Challenge in varying adoption rates by region.
- WhatsApp widely used in multiple international markets.

The problem of expensive intermediaries exists in multiple countries. Identifying regions with high WhatsApp usage and urban fresh produce demand is crucial for expansion.

**Figures to verify**

- WhatsApp usage prominent in Africa, Latin America (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Conduct market research interviews in other regions.
- Analyze urban grocery demand trends internationally.

## 3 Differentiation, Competitive Moat & Substitutes

Confidence: **Low**

- Local alternatives dominate, with Tazah and Farmdar as key players.
- WhatsApp-only model could simplify operations.
- Lack of logistics partner is a major vulnerability.
- Substitutes include direct retail and app-based solutions.

While competitors operate at larger scales, CropLink's WhatsApp model could offer ease of use. Logistics remains a critical factor for competitive edge.

**Figures to verify**

- Tazah and Farmdar are larger regional players (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Study the competitive strategies of Tazah and Farmdar.
- Test WhatsApp ordering flow against app-based systems.

## 4 Value Proposition & Product–Market Fit

Confidence: **Medium**

- Solving pain points in price transparency and access.
- Minimal tech barrier with WhatsApp-based approach.
- Farmer and consumer buy-in critical for success.
- Initial region choice important for market fit.

CropLink's promise lies in transparent pricing and ease of use, appealing to both farmers seeking better prices and urban buyers wanting fresh produce.

**Verify next**

- Pilot WhatsApp communication with farmers in Lahore/Multan.
- Examine urban consumer response to direct-from-farm procurement.

## 5 Revenue Model, Pricing Power & Unit Economics

Confidence: **Low**

- Revenue could derive from transaction fees, subscriptions.
- Pricing power depends on cutting sufficient costs.
- Unit economics hinge on logistics cost-efficiency.
- Customer value linked to price savings and freshness.

CropLink's revenue potential is significant if the platform offers clear cost savings versus mandi sales. However, logistics inefficiencies could impact profitability.

**Figures to verify**

- Farmers lose approximately 30-40% to middlemen (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Test different pricing models with initial users.
- Develop financial models based on potential logistics partnerships.

## 6 Customer Acquisition, Retention & Lifetime Value

Confidence: **Medium**

- WhatsApp is widely used globally, easing customer acquisition.
- Retention depends on consistent service and competitive pricing.
- Lifetime value is higher if middlemen elimination is consistent.
- Farmers' loyalty hinges on getting better prices directly.

Leveraging WhatsApp for direct market access is innovative, focusing on ease of use. Retaining customers requires consistent qualitative and quantitative improvements in pricing.

**Figures to verify**

- WhatsApp adoption rate in target regions is very high (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Conduct user interviews with farmers and grocery owners.
- Pilot test the order process via WhatsApp.

## 7 Technical Feasibility, Innovation & Scalability

Confidence: **Medium**

- WhatsApp API can be integrated for business use.
- Scalability depends on automation of the ordering process.
- No need for customers to learn a new app.
- Innovation is in using existing tech differently.

Technical feasibility is moderate, as WhatsApp API supports needed functions, but requires development skills. Scalability hinges on seamless integration and process automation.

**Figures to verify**

- WhatsApp users globally: 2 billion monthly (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Consult a developer for WhatsApp API integration.
- Prototype a bot for handling orders.

## 8 Country-by-Country Regulation, Privacy & IP Protection

Confidence: **Low**

- Data privacy laws vary per country.
- IP protection less critical, as innovation is service-based.
- WhatsApp enforces its own data protection standards.
- Regulations regarding direct farmer selling differ.

Differing regulations across countries necessitate careful study of target markets, especially concerning data privacy and direct selling permissions.

**Figures to verify**

- Pakistan's data protection regime is less stringent (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Consult legal experts for compliance guidelines.
- Review WhatsApp's data handling policies.

## 9 Localization, Partnerships & Go-to-Market Strategy

Confidence: **Medium**

- Localization involves language and cultural relevance.
- Partnerships with local logistics are crucial.
- Local market knowledge is vital initially.
- Gradual geographical expansion advised.

Local nuances in language and culture crucial for entry success. Critical partnerships needed with local logistics providers for effective operations and customer reach.

**Figures to verify**

- Local dialects should be considered in marketing (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Explore partnerships with local logistics firms.
- Survey potential customers for language preferences.

## 10 Capital Requirements, Risk Exposure & Long-Term Resilience

Confidence: **Low**

- Initial budget may limit expansive marketing.
- Logistical risks include delivery failures.
- Market volatility affects pricing strategies.
- Long-term resilience depends on network effects.

Managing resources effectively is crucial, focusing on critical partnerships to mitigate logistical risks. Establishing network effects builds long-term resilience.

**Figures to verify**

- Initial funding budget of PKR 500,000-1,000,000 (estimate)

**Verify next**

- Conduct a financial analysis for initial and break-even costs.
- Assess risks with potential logistics partners.

## Global: key risks

| Key risk | Mitigation |
|---|---|
| **Technical integration challenges** | Hire a technical consultant to guide WhatsApp API integration. |
| **Regulatory compliance issues** | Consult with regional legal experts on agricultural direct selling laws. |
| **Logistics reliability** | Build partnerships with reliable local logistics companies. |
| **Market acceptance** | Pilot the service in selected regions to validate demand before wider rollouts. |

## Global: next 90 days

| When | Action |
|---|---|
| **Days 1-30** | Conduct market research through interviews and surveys with potential users. |
| **Days 31-60** | Develop a prototype of the WhatsApp ordering process with technical help. |
| **Days 61-90** | Pilot the service in selected areas to test demand and logistics. |

About this research. It was written by an AI agent from its own knowledge, not from live web browsing, so it can be out of date or wrong. Figures marked (estimate) are reasoned guesses, not sourced statistics. Confidence shows how sure the agent is of each area. Treat everything here as a set of hypotheses to check with customer interviews, price tests, competitor review, official filings and transparent financial assumptions before making decisions.